but mostly ascetic movements. Of these, Jainism and Buddhism enjoyed the greatest success. Both faiths shared the Brahminical belief in *moksha* – liberation from the endless cycle of birth, death and rebirth – as an ultimate goal. What made them heterodox and heretical was their belief that this could be achieved not through the intervention of divine forces directed by priest-led prayers and sacrifices but by individual action, by following the teachings of those who had already achieved such *moksha*.

The revolutionary nature of the teachings of Gautama Sakyamuni (the Buddha), the founder of Buddhism, was first articulated by the German Indologist Albrecht Weber in the 1880s when he wrote that Buddhism was 'in its origin one of the most magnificent and radical reactions in favour of the universal human rights of the individual against the oppressing tyranny of the pretended privileges of divine origin of birth and of class'.[9] That 'radical reaction' was equally a feature of Jain teaching as originally expounded by a Kshatriya named Vardhaman, who came to be known as Mahavira, 'the great hero', believed to be the last in a line of twenty-four *tirthankara*s or 'ford-crossers' who were said to have preceded him. It was to these departed saints rather than to any deities that Jains directed their prayers as a means to obtaining their own liberation.

Thanks to royal patronage and the extensive trading links of the mercantile classes, Jainism spread throughout the Gangetic plains and beyond, even though theological differences led to its division into two sects: the Digambaras, or 'sky-clad', who spurned clothing and believed that women lacked the spiritual qualities to attain *moksha* and had first to be reborn as men; and the Svetambaras, or 'white-clad', who accepted women as nuns. That schism may well have been the real reason why the leader of the Digambaras decided to migrate south.